That purpose was to convey some basic understanding of underlying physical ideas and of the essential mathematical tools that are needed in order to express these ideas properly.

Whereas laughter played a key part of his success in holding an audience's attention, more important to the conveying of understanding was the immediacy of his approach. Indeed, he had an extraordinarily direct no-nonsense style. He scorned airy-fairy philosophizing where it had little physical content. Even his attitude to mathematics was somewhat similar. He had little use for pedantic mathematical niceties, but he had a distinctive mastery of the mathematics that he needed, and could present it in a powerfully transparent way. He was beholden to no one, and would never take on trust what others might maintain to be true without himself coming to an independent judgment. Accordingly, his approach was often strikingly original whether in his research or teaching. And when Feynman's way differed significantly from what had gone before, it would be a reasonably sure bet that Feynman's approach would be the more fruitful one to follow.

Feynman's preferred method of communication was verbal. He did not easily, or often, commit himself to the printed word. In his scientific papers, the special "Feynman" qualities would certainly come through, though in a somewhat muted form. It was in his lectures that his talents were given full reign. His exceedingly popular "Feynman Lectures" were basically edited transcripts (by Robert B. Leighton and Matthew Sands) of lectures that Feynman gave, and the compelling nature of the text is evident to anyone who reads it. The *Six Not-So-Easy Pieces* that are presented here are taken from those accounts. Yet, even here, the printed words alone leave something significantly missing. To sense the full excitement that Feynman's lectures exude, I believe that it is important to hear his actual voice. The directness of Feynman's approach, the irreverence, and the humor then become things that we can immediately share in. Fortunately, there are recordings of all the lectures presented in this book, which give us this opportunity—and I strongly recommend, if the opportunity is there, that at least some